

THE MOVE

Their word + "how?" — "Weird how?" / "Intense how?" / "Messy how?" -> Small comment first — "That sounds like the important word. Intense how?" -> Meaning check — "When you say 'freeing', what do you mean?" -> Two options — ?

START HERE

Pick the word carrying the most emotional charge and ask "[word] how?" — "Weird how?", "Intense how?", "Messy how?", "Freeing how?"

SAY THIS

Quick openers	<i>"Weird how?"</i>
Warm / connecting	<i>"That word sounds like it carries a bit. What made it feel that way?"</i>
Social / dating	<i>"That sentence is doing a lot of work. 'Weird' how?"</i>
Professional / leader...	<i>"When you say 'risky', what risk are you most concerned about?"</i>
Conflict-softening	<i>"You said it felt 'dismissive'. What made it land that way?"</i>
Digital / text	<i>"Good-weird or bad-weird?"</i>

AVOID

- They are giving short answers, rushed, distracted, or clearly not interested in expanding.
- The word is too private, painful or sensitive for the depth of the relationship.
- Your tone might sound sceptical, mocking or cross-examining.

REMEMBER

The loaded word is the doorway.